



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Auburn Classical Academy

School Website: <https://www.auburnclassicalacademy.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Auburn Classical Academy (ACA) presents itself as a private, K–8 classical, Christian school located in Opelika, Alabama. The school builds its program around the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), a Latin/Greek emphasis, and a classical literature canon, all integrated within a Christ-centered framework guided by a distinctive triad—Veritas (truth), Familia (family), Schola (school). Public materials highlight a strong partnership with parents, liturgical elements such as chapel, and a memory-based, recital-forward pedagogy in the early grades, with seminar- or rhetoric-oriented opportunities in the upper grades. Across the six classical criteria, ACA demonstrates a robust classical orientation, with Element 4 (Pedagogy) showing the most room for consolidation toward a fully classical pedagogy. Overall, ACA is classified as CLASSICAL.

Key evidence includes: explicit articulation of Veritas/Theology embedded in curricula and practice; Trivium-based framing and explicit reference to Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric; Latin/Greek study and a canon of classical literature and primary sources; emphasis on memory work, recitation, and rhetoric in upper grades; liturgical and communal practices (weekly chapel, assemblies); and a strong, faith-infused partnership with parents and a family-centered calendar. Citations drawn from ACA's public materials include the Distinctives section and FAQ (for liturgical practices and Christian identity), the Academics page (Trivium and liberal arts framing), the Curricula pages (Latin/Greek and Classical Literature), and the Parent/Community materials (Familia, partnership with parents, and family events). See citations for concrete textual evidence.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Veritas as central framing: "VERITAS — As Christ is the Truth (Veritas in Latin)" anchors education in truth and a Christian worldview. - The Apostles' Creed and Holy Scriptures are cited as foundational to education, aligning theology with curriculum. - Weekly chapel and liturgical integration are described as part of the school's communal fabric. The FAQ notes that a Wednesday assembly includes a Chapel lesson. - Public language emphasizes a Christ-centered, gospel-guided education and integrity of Christian identity alongside a broad liberal-arts mission.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: truth, veritas, creed, scriptures, gospel, chapel, liturgy, Christ, God. - Negative indicators: none observed in public materials; no explicit relativism or secular-humanist signals evident.

Why this rating - The materials consistently frame education as a theistic, transcendent pursuit anchored in truth and virtue, with liturgical/moral formation embedded in classroom life and communal worship. This aligns strongly with the Positive keyword set for Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and minimizes negative signals.

Cited evidence: Veritas framing, Apostles' Creed/Holy Scriptures, and liturgical practice.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly grounds its approach in the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and positions education as formation through the liberal-arts tradition. This is visible in the Academics page: "The Trivium works through a child's natural stages of development... Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric." - The public materials emphasize a classical mission beyond vocational training, with a focus on virtue, wisdom, and lifelong learning rather than simply job preparation. The Distinctives and Academics framing stress formation and the classical tradition.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, telos, scholé (contemplation/rest), great conversation (implied via classical canon). - Negative indicators: none observed in public materials; no emphasis on workforce-preparation language that would signal a non-classical orientation.

Why this rating - ACA's stated goals emphasize virtue-driven formation, truth-seeking, and a classical education consistent with a paideia/trivium-driven telos, meeting the core expectations for School Purpose and Goal in classical education.

Cited evidence: Trivium framing; formation/virtue language and classical mission.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Core curriculum described as liberal-arts orientation via the Trivium: Grammar, Logic, and Rhetoric explicitly identified as the three central liberal arts. - History is integrated across the curriculum with classical/historical content (Greek/Roman history, ancient world literature); primary sources and classical texts appear across grade levels (The Iliad, The Odyssey, The Book of the Ancient World; Beowulf, Shakespeare in later grades). This is visible in Classical Studies and Upper School/Grade-level syllabi. - Latin and Greek begin early and intensify; Latin grammar and vocabulary are central, with Greek introduced in upper grades; Latin forms are aligned with Memoria Press materials. - Great Books/Great Conversation-like approach is represented through a canon of classical literature (Iliad, Odyssey, Aeneid, Beowulf, The Lion, the Witch and the Wardrobe, etc.), with primary texts and poetry, emphasizing "the Great Conversation" implicit in reading the classics.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: liberal arts, grammar/logic/rhetoric, great books, classics, Latin, Greek, Western civilization, primary sources, recitation/narration/dictation, sacred literature. - Negative indicators: no evident replacement of history with social studies terminology; no explicit dominance of project-based learning over classical content.

Why this rating - The curriculum centers on the classical triad, classical languages, and a canon of Western/classical literature with explicit Liberal Arts framing, matching core Classical criteria in Curriculum.

Cited evidence: Trivium framing; Latin/Greek progression; canonical literature and primary sources.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Lower grades emphasize memory, recitation, and singing as a pedagogical approach (copybooks, memorization of poems and Scripture, and memory-based learning), which aligns with Scholé-era pedagogy (restful, contemplative, memory-driven). Primary materials reference memory work and recitation in K-2 and related practices. - Upper grades emphasize rhetoric and the ability to give speeches; some elements of disciplined, teacher-led instruction are described (teacher-directed lessons; quiet, orderly classrooms) with a clear progression toward rhetoric in higher grades. - The site emphasizes Socratic/seminar-style pedagogy more implicitly (through the mention of logic/rhetoric and rhetoric-driven assessment) but does not consistently document formal Socratic seminars or Paideia-style seminars across the full grade span. The explicit phrase "Socratic discussion" or structured seminars is not consistently evidenced in the public materials.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: recitation, narration, memory work, chanting/singing, copybook, rhetoric training, speech/declamation, seminar-style instruction (implied in the rhetoric focus). - Negative indicators present: limited explicit documentation of ongoing Socratic seminars, Paideia-style seminars, or extensive student-directed constructivist approaches; lack of explicit “Socratic” terminology in public pages.

Why this rating - ACA demonstrates many core classical pedagogy elements (memory-based learning in the grammar stage; emphasis on rhetoric and formal oratory in upper grades). However, the public materials do not consistently document frequent, explicit Socratic seminars or a fully articulated, seminar-driven upper-school pedagogy. Thus, the Pedagogy rating is SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Cited evidence: Primary K–2 memory/recitation; upper-grade rhetoric training; limited explicit Socratic/seminar documentation.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school highlights governance and faculty structure (Board of Governors; list of faculty/staff) and presents a professional culture with an emphasis on teachers and mentors within a “living curriculum.” The governance page lists a board and interim head of school, and the Faculty/Staff section identifies the roles in the school. - Distinctives present a vision of teachers who model virtue and serve as the core of the school community (e.g., the “Schola” framing and the emphasis on a faith-guided, classical formation). While the exact phrase “living curriculum” isn’t always spelled out in every page, the public materials consistently emphasize teacher leadership, mentor roles, and a classical educator identity rooted in virtue and faith. - The public materials present a teacher-anchored culture with a clear alignment between faculty roles and the school’s classical mission (Latin/Greek teachers, literature specialists, etc.).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: model teachers, mentors, living curriculum (conceptually embedded in Distinctives), portrait of teacher/student ideals, faculty as core/center of the school. - Negative indicators: none clearly observed in public materials; no explicit negative signals about faculty.

Why this rating - ACA demonstrates a faculty ecosystem aligned with classical education values (teacher-led formation, mentorship, and a strong sense of faculty as central to the school’s curriculum). This aligns with CLASSICAL signals in Faculty.

Cited evidence: Governance/faculty pages; Distinctives framing.

Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Partnership with parents and parental primacy is explicitly stated: “In partnership with parents... guided by the Word of God, we seek to educate students to the highest standards of the classical tradition.” The school emphasizes parent involvement and a home-school partnership (e.g., “Familia” pillar). - Programs for parent formation and engagement are described, including classics book clubs and parent-oriented offerings (e.g., “Classics Books For Parents,” parent gatherings). The site notes parent formation opportunities and classical education education resources for families. - Open campus and family-centric events are highlighted (Family Events, P.E. activities, festivals, and programs). The public pages showcase ongoing family involvement and events, reinforcing community integration.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive indicators present: partnership with parents, co-teaching language, parent formation, classical book clubs, family events, open campus/visits. - Negative indicators: none observed in public materials; no customer-service language or minimal parental involvement.

Why this rating - ACA emphasizes robust parental partnership, community engagement, and family-centered programming, aligning strongly with the Parents & Community category of classical education.

Cited evidence: Parent partnership language; Classics book clubs; Family events; open campus.

Aggregate Assessment - Category standings: CLASSICAL (1), CLASSICAL (2), CLASSICAL (3), SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL (4), CLASSICAL (5), CLASSICAL (6) - Overall, ACA is CLASSICAL.

What would move the needle (for SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL category) - Pedagogy (Element 4): Introduce explicit, regular, documented Socratic seminars and Paideia-style seminars across the upper grades, with formal rubrics and evidence of student-led discourse. Clarify and publish a formal Paideia/Socratic approach in the curriculum narrative, including sample seminar prompts, assessment rubrics, and teacher professional development materials. - Curriculum (Element 3): Strengthen explicit language around Great Books and Great Conversation in public materials (e.g., a formal "Great Books Program" statement, a published canon list with reading milestones, and a documented rationale for selections linked to the Trivium's objectives). - Public articulation of "living curriculum" (Element 5): Provide explicit language and examples showing how teachers embody the living-curriculum concept in daily practice (e.g., portraits of teacher-mentors, faculty development plans, and examples of how teacher modeling shapes student learning).

Implemented changes along these lines would move the Pedagogy and perhaps other categories from SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL toward CLASSICAL across the board.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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